

READING PASSAGE 2

The Formation of Coral Atolls

A The study of the formation of coral atolls has undergone a remarkable transformation over the past several decades. What was once a niche area of academic inquiry has developed into a rich and diverse field of research, drawing on insights from a wide range of disciplines and theoretical traditions.

B The origins of contemporary research in this area can be traced to pioneering studies conducted during the mid-twentieth century. These early investigations, though constrained by the technological and methodological limitations of their era, established foundational principles that continue to inform current scholarship. Successive generations of researchers have built upon these foundations, progressively refining theoretical models and expanding the empirical evidence base through increasingly sophisticated research designs.

C Contemporary research has identified several critical factors that determine outcomes in this domain. The interplay between environmental conditions, technological capabilities, and social organisation creates a complex adaptive system in which small changes can produce disproportionately large effects. Understanding these dynamics requires analytical approaches that move beyond simple cause-and-effect reasoning to embrace the principles of complexity science and systems thinking.

D The empirical record is further strengthened by a series of meta-analyses that have synthesised findings from hundreds of individual studies. These comprehensive reviews have consistently identified moderate to large effect sizes, with the most robust findings demonstrating remarkable consistency across different research designs, measurement approaches, and analytical strategies. This convergence of evidence from multiple independent lines of inquiry considerably strengthens confidence in the validity of the core theoretical propositions.

E Several unresolved debates continue to animate scholarly discussion in this field. Perhaps the most prominent concerns the relative importance of structural versus agentic factors in determining outcomes. While some researchers emphasise the constraining power of institutional and economic structures, others highlight the capacity of individuals and groups to exercise agency and effect change even within seemingly restrictive contexts. This debate has significant practical implications, as it shapes recommendations for policy interventions and institutional reforms.

F The implications of this body of research extend well beyond the academy. As societies grapple with increasingly complex challenges, the insights generated by scholarly inquiry in this domain have the potential to inform more effective and equitable policy responses. Realising this potential, however, will require sustained investment in both fundamental research and the translational infrastructure needed to convert knowledge into action.

G The evidence reviewed above demonstrates both the substantial achievements of research in this field and the significant work that remains to be done. As new tools and theoretical perspectives become available, and as the phenomena themselves continue to evolve, the research community will need to maintain both rigour in its methods and openness to new ideas. The stakes are high, for the questions addressed by this research bear directly on some of the most important challenges facing humanity in the twenty-first century.

Question 1

Do the following statements agree with the information given in the passage?

Write TRUE if the statement agrees with the information

Write FALSE if the statement contradicts the information

Write NOT GIVEN if there is no information on this

- 1 Contemporary understanding of this topic is more sophisticated than it was fifty years ago.

Question 2

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

- 2 According to the text, what role do structural factors play?
- A. excessive research funding
 - B. translating academic findings into practical policy
 - C. lack of public interest
 - D. too many international collaborations

Question 3

Complete the sentences below. Choose NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS from the passage for each answer.

- 3 Dynamic _____ processes can amplify or dampen initial effects in complex systems.

Questions 4–5

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

- 4 What does the passage identify as a significant challenge to current understanding?
- A. excessive research funding
 - B. translating academic findings into practical policy
 - C. lack of public interest
 - D. too many international collaborations
- 5 According to the text, what role do structural factors play?
- A. weak effects across studies
 - B. moderate to large effect sizes with consistency
 - C. contradictory findings
 - D. results only in specific populations

Question 6

Do the following statements agree with the information given in the passage?

Write TRUE if the statement agrees with the information

Write FALSE if the statement contradicts the information

Write NOT GIVEN if there is no information on this

- 6 The passage suggests that structural factors are less important than individual choices.

Question 7

Complete the sentences below. Choose NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS from the passage for each answer.

- 7 The passage identifies power _____ as a key factor at the organisational level.

Question 8

Do the following statements agree with the information given in the passage?

Write TRUE if the statement agrees with the information

Write FALSE if the statement contradicts the information

Write NOT GIVEN if there is no information on this

- 8 Meta-analyses have confirmed the reliability of the core findings in this field.

Question 9

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

- 9 According to the passage, what is one of the key factors identified by researchers?
- A. minimal impact
 - B. creating underlying conditions for action
 - C. determining individual choices directly
 - D. irrelevant to outcomes

Question 10

Complete the sentences below. Choose NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS from the passage for each answer.

- 10 The author notes that researchers have called for more _____ approaches to investigation.

Question 11

Do the following statements agree with the information given in the passage?

Write TRUE if the statement agrees with the information

Write FALSE if the statement contradicts the information

Write NOT GIVEN if there is no information on this

- 11 Early researchers had access to the same technologies as modern scholars.

Question 12

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

- 12 According to the passage, what is one of the key factors identified by researchers?
- A. excessive funding
 - B. theoretical and methodological limitations
 - C. public interest
 - D. international collaboration

Question 13

Complete the sentences below. Choose NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS from the passage for each answer.

13 Case studies have documented the effects of _____ change on the system.